

IN THE CLASSROOM: Selwyn Elementary School

Rescued hawk lifts off to cheers

3rd-grader discovered sick bird on campus

By JENNIFER WING ROTHACKER
Staff Writer

The Selwyn Hawk looked a bit stunned.

First, he had just gotten over an infection where he couldn't eat or fly. He spent a month at the Raptor Center recovering.

And now, here were about 50 third-graders staring at him, waiting for him to fly back to freedom. Such pressure.

But with a nudge from Carolina Raptor Center employee Betty O'Leary, the hawk found his wings worked. He flew amid bare trees back to his home.

For the students, his return to flight was a free science lesson delivered by nature. It happened to fit nicely into the students' Fee-

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GAYLE SHOMER/Staff

Betty O'Leary of the Carolina Raptor Center releases a rehabilitated hawk that had been found injured along a nature path at Selwyn Elementary School. O'Leary brought the hawk back to be released outside the school as students watched.

Schoolchildren applaud Selwyn Hawk's takeoff

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derWatch curriculum sponsored by Cornell University.

The school's fifth- and third-graders watch bird feeders from their classrooms and record which birds come to eat.

That information is sent to Cornell, which studies it for such things as migration tendencies. The students also produce a newsletter and talk via Internet with students in other states involved in the project.

"It's different from most classroom activities," said Carter MacBain, a parent volunteer. "It's a re-

search project."

The Selwyn Hawk dived into the students' lives and studies.

One Saturday in January, third-grader Jane Hall was walking with her mom, her younger brother Drew and his friend Davis on Selwyn's nature trail.

Suddenly they came upon this puffy creature at the base of a tree.

"I thought it was an owl because we have owls in our back yard," said Jane, 8.

Realizing the bird was not acting right, Jane's mom went to her car to call for help. Jane stayed behind to make sure no dogs pounced on the hawk.

The Raptor Center came to the

trail and scooped up the bird, which was agitated and ruffling his feathers. The center's doctors ran tests and learned the bird had an infection.

After a dose of antibiotics, the Selwyn Hawk improved. He was identified as a red-tailed hawk, said the Raptor Center's O'Leary.

Gradually the hawk regained strength. Thursday he flew back into the world.

The joy of seeing the bird take flight elicited cheers from the students. For Jane, seeing the bird she helped find and nurture return home stirred one feeling:

"Happy."